CHAPTER 8 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The Siege of Petersburg

Nine months in the trenches below Richmond — where the war stopped looking like the past and started looking like the future. 1864–1865.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Nine months in the trenches below Richmond — where the war stopped looking like the past and started looking like the future. 1864–1865.

How do you know when a new kind of warfare has been born?

The War Goes Underground

JUNE 1864

After the slaughter of the Overland Campaign, Grant pinned Lee's army at Petersburg, the rail junction that supplied Richmond. Lee could not afford to lose it — and Grant knew it.

Unable to take the city by storm, both armies dug in. What followed was not a battle but a siege — nine months of trenches, forts, and constant, grinding attrition.

"The Dictator" — a 13-inch mortar on a railroad car before Petersburg, Virginia — photograph, 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

Industrial Firepower

BEFORE PETERSBURG, 1864

"The Dictator," a 13-inch mortar mounted on a railroad car, lobbed 200-pound shells into the Confederate lines. The war was now a contest of industry and heavy machinery.

"The Dictator" — a 13-inch mortar on a railroad car before Petersburg, Virginia — photograph, 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Preview of a Darker Future

THE TRENCH LINES

Miles of trenches, earthworks, and sharpened log barriers (chevaux-de-frise) stretched across the landscape. Fifty years later, the armies of World War I would fight almost exactly like this.

Chevaux-de-frise before the Confederate works at Petersburg, Virginia — photograph, 1865, public domain (Library of Congress).

From Napoleon to the Trenches

HOW WAR HAD CHANGED

Early in the war, armies still fought in the old style: long lines of men marching into the open to trade volleys. But rifled muskets and artillery made that style suicidal, as Cold Harbor had shown.

At Petersburg the response was trenches — men dug in, protected by earth, and the front barely moved for months. This was a profound change: war was becoming a stalemate of machines, logistics, and endurance, not a single glorious charge.

Chevaux-de-frise before the Confederate works at Petersburg, Virginia — photograph, 1865, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Line Finally Breaks

THE END

For nine months Grant extended his lines, stretching Lee's shrinking army thinner and thinner. Finally, in April 1865, the line snapped. Lee abandoned Petersburg and Richmond and fled west — with Grant in pursuit.

The siege had done exactly what Grant intended: it had worn the Confederate army down past the breaking point. The end was now only days away.

Turning points, 1863–65 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Mark the Change

YOUR TURN

You'll compare how armies fought at the war's start and at Petersburg, and practice change over time — identifying what ended, what began, and why it mattered.